2024 POST TRIP REPORT

Project Battambang

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

01 Introduction.....

02 Vision, Mission and Values....

03 Foreword.....

04 Timeline.....

05 Screening.....

06 Logistics.....

07 Education.....

08 Our LADs Scholars .....

09 Development.....

10 Publicity.....

11 The Battambang Experience.....

12 Financial Report.....

13 Acknowledgements.....

14 Sponsors.....

INTRODUCTION

Recognizing the need for improved healthcare and education systems in Cambodia, Project Battambang was born from of a collective desire to make a positive impact and address the challenges faced by underserved populations in the Poipet community.

Over time, members of the project became aware that continuous provision of support and aid would become unfeasible in the long run. As such, Project Battambang has looked to place a stronger focus on sustainability and long-term partnerships in Poipet, striving to empower the local youth and foster social change.

At its core, Project Battambang tries to empower the community through the following various ways:

Supporting Local Systems:

Project Battambang collaborates with local healthcare and educational institutions to make it more accessible to its people. This includes provision of primary healthcare to its people and resources to schools to make the learning environment safer and more conducive.

Sustainable Partnerships:

The project focuses on building enduring partnerships with local organisations and community leaders, such as the Mother of Peace Kindergarten (MOPK) and Love Without Boundaries (LWB). By fostering strong relationships, Project Battambang ensures that its interventions are sustainable and have a lasting impact.

Youth Empowerment:

In the pursuit of social change, Project Battambang persists in its belief in the potential of youth. Anchored in the provision of educational opportunities and active engagement in community development initiatives, the project envisions young individuals as vital agents for positive change in Poipet.

MISSION

We resolve to improve the provision of healthcare and education through partnerships and support the local systems, and to empower youth to effect greater social awareness and responsibility within the community.

VISION

We envision an independent community where everyone has the liberty and means to hope for and achieve a better future together.

VALUES: LIBRAS

Love	Loving the people we serve and our team members
Integrity	Being consistent and truthful
Beneficence	For the benefit of community
Respect	Our beneficiaries as equal partners
Accountability	Staying accountable to our beneficiaries and partners
Sustainability	Consider long-term benefits

FOREWORD:

Dr. Derek Soon
Adjunct Associate Professor
Senior Consultant Neurologist

Thank you, Project Battambang, for seeking out the poorest and the most neglected of our brothers and sisters, to encounter them in their places of poverty, to engage them in a dialogue of Love.

Thank you, Project Battambang, for molding our medical students. Each one earnestly striving to become selfless, generous and courageous doctors, and discovering their identity through your pedagogy of service and charity

Thank you, Project Battambang, for the collaborative connections with our Cambodian colleagues, for the professional and educational bonds you foment, which opens the door to deeper, more enduring clinical and developmental collaborations of tomorrow.

Thank you, Project Battambang, for facilitating the education of children of the slums and rubbish dumps, for through these projects they are given a chance of fully realizing and living out their mission in life.

Thank you, Project Battambang, for adopting the long-term view. As a result, some of the villages you initially served have been elevated out of extreme poverty, allowing your workers to shift their focus onto new areas in need.

Thank you, Project Battambang, for through your initiatives you have brought warmth and illumination into places of physical and spiritual darkness. Introduced joy where there was despondency; friendship where there was antipathy; empowerment where there was powerlessness; hope where there was despair.

And thank you, Project Battambang, for your generosity in inviting me, a seasoned clinician of thirty years, to participate and share in your bounty of fresh-eyed, optimistic, unconditional service.

You have planted a seed of delight in my heart.

TIMELINE:

2010

- Inception of Project Battambang, born from a vision of Dr Ong and five Year Two medical students
- Provision of Health Screening services and health education
- Served 201 villagers across 4 villages

2011

- Introduction of Light- A-Dream scholarship
- Introduction of Teachers' Support Programme
- Formation of survey committee to find out the non-medical concerns of the villages we served
- Hired translators

2012

- LIBRAS, our 6 guiding values, was created along with our vision and mission
- Establishment of Screening Referral programme
- Mobile screenings were established for patients who were unable to come to our screening sites

2013

- Introduction of LADS Camp
- Health screening expanded to serve 1595 villagers
- Cambodian wing of the project run entirely by student volunteers from UHS and IU

2014

- Introduction of dental services
- Graduation of 2 LADS scholars, 2 Graduating doctors return to volunteer in screenings
- Collaboration with SEVA Cambodia
- Introduction of Participatory Learning and Action Toolkit (PLA) during surveys

2015

- Eye screening services were introduced and prescription glasses were provided as required
- Project Battambang Cambodian Committee established
- Provision of water pots in Prey Koup

2016

- Singed Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with IU, formally outlining Singaporean and Cambodian committees' support for Project Battambang
- Provision of supplemental waterpots

2017

- Teacher's Support Programme (TSP) replaced by School Support Programme (SSP)
- Health Education Day established
- More robust chronic disease management system; Telehealth and prescription cards
- Introduction of Door-To-Door Groundwork methodology during surveys

2018

- Expansion of dental screenings; established partnerships with two local dental clinics
- Established partnership with local optic shop, Heng Optic
- Implementation of SSP - funding the construction of a well and a toilet in Santipheap school Introduction of buddy system with LADS scholars

2019

- Expansion into new villages for health screenings
- Door-to-door Needs Assessment surveys using Magpi app
- Restructuring of survey committee into development committee
- Development of health education syllabus

2020

- Rise of COVID-19
- Unable to travel to Cambodia
- Maintained contact with our Cambodian committee
- Fund-raising efforts

2021

- With COVID-19 travel restrictions persisting, we continued our support remotely through our COVID relief support programme and engaged with the LADS scholars over Zoom. We continued to fund-raise locally as well

2022

- Resumption of Cambodia trips
- Health screenings
- Door to door surveys and groundwork to find out what has changed over the years

2023

- Collaboration with Love Without Boundaries (LWB) to organise health screenings for both of their schools
- Battambus mobile screening at Dong Aranh Village, including a team that travelled door-to-door
- Re-establishment of a permanent Cambodian Committee

2024

- Expansion of screening stations and referrals, and into 2 new villages
- Pioneering Teachers' Training across different schools
- Soap-making program and installation of a water pump at Love Without Boundaries (LWB)
- A human-centric approach to Door-to-door surveys via the Stories of Poipet initiative
- Pilot usage of VEASNA, and facial ID scanners for screening.
- Computer Lab and Sports programme at Tum Nub Kor V School.

SCREENING

Our screening committee is responsible for the planning and execution of the health screening conducted in Poipet which aims to make medical services accessible, affordable, and comprehensive to increase the overall health in these communities.

Overview:

This year, we conducted mass health screenings at three different locations – Mother Of Peace Kindergarten, Tum Nub Kor Pram and Kbal Koh – over 4 days, screening a total of 1068 villagers. This year we focused on expanding our screening stations to provide more holistic healthcare for the villagers. Such expansion was a huge success as our other healthcare professionals like physiotherapists, optometrists, and audiologists provided specialised treatment that was well received by the villagers. Our doctors also conducted mobile screenings, where we saw patients who were unable to leave their homes due to disabilities or household responsibilities.

In line with Project Battambang's long term aims of sustainability, our screening committee placed greater emphasis on developing our referral programmes, successfully referring 284 villagers to local institutions. Moreover, we also piloted the usage of our online screening system VEASNA to improve the efficiency and data collection of our screenings. Overall, this year has been an experimental one for screening, and we are excited to see our initiatives take flight and make sustainable impacts in the villages.

PRE-SCREENING

Prior to the trip, a key part of our planning focused on finalising the screening modalities and screening flow. We reviewed the needs of the villagers and incorporated new modalities that contributed to improving their health holistically (see more under 'Stations and Flow'). We then recruited healthcare professionals, and worked with them closely in preparation for the trip. For example, we were granted the privilege to learnt more about hearing aids from audiologists at WSAudiology. We also meticulously planned out screening flows for each screening location, to ensure efficiency.

We conducted a Mock Screening to familiarise our committee members with modalities and screening processes. This hands-on session allowed them to practice using equipment such as blood pressure machines, and try out Veasna (see more under 'Development').

We also worked closely with our Cambodian committee, who played an integral part in liaising with relevant stakeholders in Cambodia and translating essential documents such as our physical screening forms.

STATIONS AND FLOW

Our screening process in MOPK, Kbal Koh and TNK5 began with registration. To support sustainable healthcare, we piloted an intranet-based clinic management system and face ID scanner (see “Development”). Next, patients were triaged. Their vital signs, height & weight, and a preliminary history of their presenting illness were recorded.

Following triage, villagers visited the Education Booth. We covered a variety of topics ranging from preventive health to general hygiene. Patients with chronic illnesses received tailored flyers. Thereafter, villagers had consultations with our doctors, and received medications at the Pharmacy station.

Noticing many required non-medical aid, we expanded the healthcare team in 2024 to include Physiotherapists, Audiologists, and an Ophthalmic Care Centre worker. Our physiotherapists screened villagers with joint and muscular pains, and taught them exercises to reduce their pain.

Our audiologists helped us screen and provide hearing aids to villagers with hearing problems. This allowed many to hear clearly for the first time in years.

Our ophthalmic care centre worker provided referrals to villagers with visual problems such as cataracts for surgery to restore their eyesight.

Throughout screening, our Cambodian Committee played an integral role in helping us build ties with local healthcare partners, and connect with the villagers we served.

REFERRALS

For patients whose medical issues required diagnosing and treatment beyond what we were able to provide, we referred them to Mongkul Borey Hospital, Poipet Referral Hospital and to an optician respectively, depending on their specific condition. Project Battambang covered the medical costs incurred by patients in full.

Mongkul Borey Hospital

For patients with more severe conditions, we referred them to Mongkul Borey Hospital, which has multiple departments, such as Paediatrics and Cardiology. They had the equipment, expertise and medications required to treat these patients. One example was a lady with proptosis who required further CT scans to identify the cause of the issue.

Poipet Referral Hospital

Due to our limited equipment, we referred children and adults alike to PRH for both dental and medical care for cases in which we lacked the diagnostic equipment or relevant medications. Through this, we were able to diagnose and provide medications for patients suffering from a variety of conditions, such as tuberculosis. With its close proximity to the villages we serve, it provides a convenient avenue for the villagers to continue seeking medical treatment after we leave.

Optician

For patients with vision issues, we had the privilege of a SEVA field worker joining us to conduct more meticulous vision checks.

For patients who had cataracts, they were referred to Mongkul Borey Hospital for cataract surgery as SEVA partners with Mongkul Borey to provide free cataract surgery.

For patients with myopia and astigmatism, we referred them to a local optician partner for the villagers requiring them.

Lastly, we received a generous sponsorship of 300 reading glasses from Sightonomy, greatly benefiting villagers who were identified to suffer from presbyopia during our health screening.

POST-SCREENING

This year, we broadened our scope of screening as we introduced new modalities and expanded our referral programmes. We were privileged to have doctors, nurses, physiotherapists and audiologists join us while we established new partnerships with local stakeholders such as SEVA, Mongkol Borey Hospital, social workers and village chiefs. With the help of these stakeholders, we spearheaded the establishment of more sustainable initiatives and highlighted the importance of forging and maintaining close relationships with local partners.

Sustainability

Firstly, we sought to make our initiatives more sustainable. Often, the utility of screening in these villages lies in its ability to alleviate acute conditions. However, we recognised the value of addressing chronic conditions that plague villagers significantly. Thus, we took on a multi-pronged approach by improving our referral system and working alongside their social determinants of health. For example, we partnered up with local social workers to help villagers apply for subsidies like the Health Equity Fund, allowing them to visit government hospitals at a subsidised price. Albeit an imperfect solution with red tape that has yet to be cut, we hope such initiatives can reconnect the villagers back to their local health systems in the long run.

Local partners

Secondly, it is crucial that we partnered with local stakeholders to improve the quality and continuity of care that the villagers received. Moving forward, we hope to refine our referral process and establish stronger relationships with local health centres. By building a network that goes beyond just medical screening, we shift our focus towards creating a community where villagers are empowered to take charge of their health.

LOGISTICS

Our logistics committee is involved in the sourcing, procuring and management of the drugs required to operate the pharmacy, as well as running of the pharmacy.

Overview:

The Logistics Committee ensures the smooth operation of the project by managing resources and working with other committees to bring ideas to life. Pre-trip, we coordinated flights, transportation, meals, accommodations, and logistics with the Cambodian Committee, ensuring all materials, from masks to posters, were safely transported. We collaborated with the Sponsorships Committee to secure sponsors.

During the trip, our main role was running the pharmacy, dispensing medications, tracking drug inventory, and sourcing additional supplies as needed. We also oversaw the Hair Lice and Blood Pressure Machine initiatives, supporting the monthly hair washing program at Love Without Boundaries and helping villagers monitor and understand hypertension.

By carefully planning and adapting throughout the trip, the Logistics Committee ensured seamless execution of the project, enabling effective screening, education, and community outreach.

INITATIVES

Pharmacy

During this trip, our team successfully screened over 1000 individuals, many of whom requiring visits to the pharmacy. With invaluable support from the Cambodian Committee in translation and accurate conveyance of the relevant prescription instructions, we managed to keep the pharmacy running smoothly.

One key improvement during this year's trip was better communication with the doctors regarding medication stock at the start of each day, enabling more informed rationing of drugs across cases. This proactive measure, though requiring additional effort to stocktake after each screening, minimized care delays and ensured timely restocking when critical drugs were running low.

Moving forward, we plan to refine our processes by organizing medications by specific drug function instead of system, thereby ensuring the appropriate stocking of medication. Furthermore, we plan on leveraging this year's data to better prepare for future screenings of similar magnitude. We also aim to enhance collaboration across committees to ensure even greater efficiency in subsequent trips.

Hair Lice Removal Programme

We were heartened to receive monthly updates from LWB's principal, Leng, sharing how the children had learned to wash each other's hair. As part of our Blood Pressure Monitoring Programme, we received feedback that the villagers were actively using the machine. On this trip, we introduced laminated hypertension posters and proper recording forms to help villagers better understand hypertension risks and monitor their blood pressure more consistently.

SUSTANABILITY

In 2025, the Logistics Committee will continue to enhance the operational efficiency of the pharmacy. Some improvements we plan to make include organizing and packing our medications in a more organised way for easier stocktaking. We will continue to source for collaborations with local or Cambodian pharmacies, in order to establish a long-term partnership with them for sustainability in hopes of obtaining donated or subsidised drugs for screening.

Additionally, we will continue to monitor our Hair Lice and Blood Pressure Machine initiatives. One area for improvement we identified is the lack of knowledge among villagers on how to follow up after discovering they have hypertension. To address this, we plan to incorporate targeted education and collaborate with local leaders in subsequent trips. While our primary responsibility is managing logistics for the trip, we are committed to using any additional time to develop small initiatives that can make a meaningful difference for the people of Poipet.

Moving forward, we aim to refine our processes to optimize resource utilization and reduce waste. A key focus will be on enhancing inventory management and drug stocktaking to minimize overstocking while ensuring medications remain viable. We will pay greater attention to monitoring expiry dates after realizing that many of our drugs were close to expiring before the next trip. By continuing to collaborate closely with our Cambodian counterparts, we will ensure effective planning and procurement of logistics to support the continued success of Project Battambang.

EDUCATION

Our Education Committee is responsible for empowering our scholars through education, in order to engender greater social change within the community and advocate for self-sufficiency within the local community. The committee also works with various schools in Poipet in efforts to provide support to their school systems, supplementing and improving the lessons received by the children.

Overview:

One of the world's most revered leaders, Nelson Mandela, once said, "Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world." Backed by the legacy he left, this quote serves as a resounding reminder how transformative education can be. In alignment with our project's focus on sustainability, the team firmly believes that education lies at the center of promoting positive long-term changes in the behaviours of students and villagers. Through our initiatives, we seek to inspire Cambodians to take ownership of their health, equip them with the knowledge to do so and ultimately empower them to become advocates of health themselves. The end-goal of our education initiatives is to promote self-sufficiency and to engender greater social change so that our Cambodian counterparts can eventually take over our role as health advocates and give back to their own community.

For this trip, we tailored our initiatives to 4 main groups of people, each of which are key stakeholders within their community - screening patients, teachers, primary school students, and our Light-A-Dream Scholarship (LADS) recipients.

TEACHERS TRAINING:

Teachers' Training was pioneered for the first time this year. In Poipet, there are limited health education programmes across private and public schools, so our team set out to bridge that gap. Routines and systems are built with time and the team is cognisant of the fact that our biannual visits to educate the students are insufficient in engendering systemic changes within institutions.

As such, we chose to rope in teachers, who are key figures of influence in schools that regularly and directly deliver educational content to their students. Through providing a collaborative space for teachers from different schools to gather and exchange health knowledge, we hope for teachers to independently implement regular health education lessons and programmes in schools eventually.

In May 2024, we invited 37 teachers from 5 schools to our training at Love Without Boundaries (LWB). We split teachers across 3 classrooms and covered the following topics:

1. Puberty, with a focus on sexual education.
2. Hygiene and nutrition, including dental care, hair lice prevention and hair lice management
3. First aid

In December 2024, our programme at expanded to 60 teachers from 9 schools. Teachers were taught collectively in 1 hall and we covered the following topics.

1. Puberty, with a focus on changes that teenage males and females go through.

2. Infectious diseases and management.

3. Preventive health (eg. Smoking, Alcohol Use)

The December training was followed up by a discussion session where we gathered teachers in smaller focused groups and shared more about Singapore's education system and approach to health education. This provides a space for teachers to ask targeted questions with regards to the content we covered, and allows both Singapore and Poipet to share and learn our different learning pedagogies in schools.

During each of these events, relevant material to support the implementation of our proposed programmes were also distributed.

Posters on all content covered (eg. A3 laminated posters on handwashing and toothbrushing in Khmer) were printed and distributed to schools to paste around their campus. Other materials we provided include lice combs and conditioners. The team is delighted to report that the May edition of our Teachers' Training has inspired Love Without Boundaries school to implement its own weekly hair lice washing and combing programme.

When the dissemination of health knowledge and relevant material goods complement each other, schools are empowered to establish health-promoting programmes to improve the hygiene and wellbeing of students.

STUDENTS' EDUCATION

In December 2024, the team organised Students' Engagement concurrent with Teachers' training at LWB. Students' education was split into 3 separate booths:

1. Toothbrushing
2. Handwashing
3. Dispelling common health myths

The booths took on an interactive format, where we engaged students through activities such as eating Oreos before brushing their teeth, soap making, and games to capture their attention.

Our primary objective is to instill healthy hygiene practices amongst the students, through a fun and engaging way. It was pleasantly received by the children as they proactively participated in the activities planned for them.

Student Engagement and Teachers Training are complementary, each one reinforces the other in establishing positive health habits and health programmes in schools. We believe that these efforts will go a long way in preventing future chronic health problems that are now prevalent in Poipet.

LIGHT-A-DREAM SCHOLARSHIP (LADS)

As per previous years, LADS camp serves as a biannual gathering for all LADS scholars and hostel girls to bond and acquire knowledge. This year, we sought to enhance their learning opportunities during the camp by further integrating them into the work of our project.

In May, LADS camp was centered around Cambodia's Healthcare System and how our scholars from different fields of study can play their part to promote health within their own communities. Over the 2-day camp, scholars played games and joined us for door-to-door visits for the first time in the history of LADS camp. The opportunity to talk to villagers from Tum Nub Kor Pram Village was greatly treasured by the LADS scholars and they expressed their interest in our community visits. These visits served to build up the confidence of LADS scholars to talk to members of their community and also made them more cognisant of pertinent problems their community face.

The December iteration of LADS camp was a 2-day camp for 37 students. We chose to focus not just on delivering content, but also on fostering relationships amongst the scholars and committee members as well by adopting a more orientation-styled programme. This allowed for greater engagement of the committee through games and activities that were met with strong enthusiasm over the two days. In addition, we observed the average levels of English fluency amongst our scholars had increased greatly from last year, which helped to facilitate communication not just amongst the scholars and the Cambodian Committee, but with the SG comm as well.

The aspects we focused on were the themes of health and leadership, which were selected in hopes that these scholars would be inspired to one day be a leader in their communities. We shared leadership models and qualities of a good leader while incorporating collaborative activities like creating and performing skits and solving riddles.

This year, we also brought back 'A Better Cambodia (ABC)' project which was first established in 2013. This initiative started as a platform to encourage LADS scholars to reflect on existing gaps within their community and ideate on ways they can improve the quality of lives of the villagers around them. Our committee will then help refine their ideas and support their execution of these ideas in the months that follow. Our approach this time round incorporated elements of ABC project from the past with our current emphasis on health education. We first shared with scholars key information on dental hygiene, hair lice, and chronic diseases. Subsequently, the scholars embarked on an education-focused Door to Door visit around the MOPK village, where they facilitated their own educational talks about the health content they had learned the previous day. The scholars were encouraged to choose topics they were interested in and present the information in their own creative manner.

Through this LADS camp, we sincerely hope that the scholars formed lasting relationships and were inspired to appreciate the power of education in helping their own communities. For the next LADS camp, a more self-directed ABC project initiation and community involvement can be considered.

SUSTANABILITY

Our project heavily emphasises on “sustainability”, for which education is the theoretical “perfect” medium - one only needs to reference how Mandela revolutionised South Africa. Of course, Rome was not built in a day and the value of our education efforts cannot be felt in the short run. Rewards of our education efforts may never be quantified, given its intangible effects on the lives of Cambodians, but the team strongly believes that health education is an irreplaceable complement to our screening efforts and has limitless potential in effecting positive change in the schools and villages of Poipet.

Upon reflection, we are delighted by the success of our initiatives (as highlighted above), but there remains room for growth.

First, we hope to expand education during screening beyond the traditional lecture-style using A3 posters. We have observed that interest levels were inconsistent, due to low literacy rates among villagers and overwhelming information in a small page. Moving forward, we will switch to pre-recorded education materials in forms of short video for better engagement and retention.

Second, the language barrier was a significant hurdle during LADs camp and teacher’s training. Though carefully designed, our educational materials may not have effectively communicated the intended message across due to translation and interpretation discrepancies. The language barrier also hinders bonding between the Singapore committee and LADS scholars. Moving forward, we hope to have greater collaboration with our Cambodian Committee and work on planning and designing materials together.

Third, now that we have successfully trialed Teachers’ Training and Student Engagement sessions in LWB, we hope to expand our teachings to more schools in Poipet. This will be done after careful consideration of each schools’ individual needs. There are also plans to organise a career fair to increase students’ exposure to potential job opportunities.

DEVELOPMENT

Our Development Committee oversees the collection and analysis of data regarding the individuals we serve, utilizing this information to strategically guide the direction of our project. Additionally, we are responsible for coming up with and bringing to life new and inventive ideas to further the project's goals.

Overview:

The Development team focuses on understanding the needs of the communities we serve and devising innovative solutions to meet these needs. As custodians of the project's strategic direction, our scope is broad and impactful. This includes conducting recce trips to identify target villages and performing both needs-based and asset-based assessments. We achieve this through epidemiological studies via door-to-door surveys, as well as qualitative interviews with village chiefs and school principals.

Our data is meticulously processed through rigorous analysis and complemented with on-the-ground experiences to inform both current and future initiatives. Beyond planning, Development also evaluates and enhances ongoing initiatives. For instance, our Veasna application was trialled this year during screenings, exemplifying our commitment to leveraging technology for efficiency and accuracy. The process of continuously iterating our tools ensures that we are responsive to both technological advancements and the evolving needs of the communities we serve.

Our role extends to ensuring that health interventions remain holistic, addressing social determinants of health and tackling root causes of illnesses. By integrating interdisciplinary knowledge beyond healthcare, we complement clinical initiatives with sustainable, non-clinical interventions such as improving water quality. Collaborating with local partners ensures that our efforts are grounded in sustainability and cultural sensitivity, enabling long-term impact beyond the duration of our visits. Our ongoing efforts reflect the belief that systemic change is possible through thoughtful planning and community-centred approaches.

DOOR-TO-DOOR SURVEYS

During our May trip, the Development team surveyed four villages, conducting qualitative interviews with village chiefs and school principals to understand each community's unique assets and challenges. Teams were dispatched to individual households to interview residents, gaining invaluable insights into their needs and circumstances. We utilised satellite images to assign teams to specific sectors, preventing overlapping data collection and enabling us to break down epidemiological data by sector. Our door-to-door surveys also flagged immobile patients, allowing teams with doctors to provide care to these individuals during screening days.

This year, we revamped our door-to-door surveys, transitioning to a fully digital system. Utilising offline Google Sheets with dropdown menus, we streamlined quantitative data collection and analysis, making the process more efficient and user-friendly. We also developed a custom AI-powered tool to clean and analyze data, producing detailed graphs that provided a comprehensive epidemiological understanding of the communities we serve. This rapid, accurate analysis informed many of the project's overarching strategies and initiatives, ensuring data-driven decision-making.

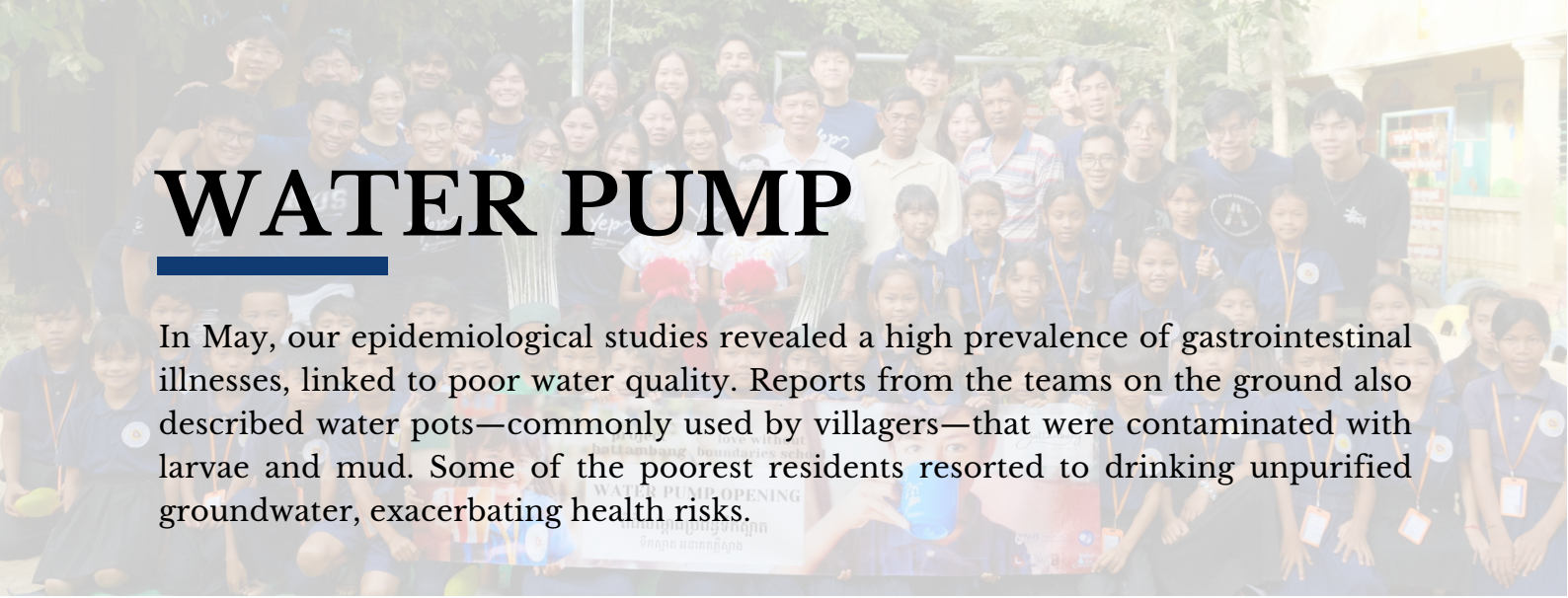
In addition to the technical advancements, our door-to-door surveys provided an invaluable opportunity for engagement with the community. By speaking directly with residents, our team built trust and rapport, laying the groundwork for future collaborations. These conversations often uncovered nuanced challenges and highlighted potential areas for intervention, ensuring that our efforts remained relevant and impactful.

STORIES OF POIPET

In December, we shifted away from traditional quantitative data collection to focus on a more human-centric approach. Recognizing the limitations of purely statistical methods, we embraced freeform home interviews to understand villagers as individuals rather than just patients. This approach allowed us to connect with the community beyond simply gathering data, allowing us to foster a deeper appreciation of their strength, resilience, and tenacity amidst adversity.

The experience was both heart-wrenching and enlightening. Each team was equipped with a film camera, encouraging intentional photography that captured the essence of the villagers and their homes—spaces both personal and profoundly different from our own. This initiative culminated in the creation of the Stories of Poipet book, which complements our quantitative efforts from May. Through this project, we seek to convey the heartbeat of a city often misunderstood, highlighting its humanity beyond the cold abstraction of statistics.

The Stories of Poipet initiative not only documented the lived experiences of the community but also served as a tool for advocacy and awareness. Sharing these stories with stakeholders has helped us foster a deeper connection with supporters, inspiring ongoing partnerships. Additionally, the initiative emphasised the value of storytelling in humanitarian work, providing a medium to reflect the complexities of the communities we serve. We invite you to read the book, which captures the indomitable spirit of Poipet.



WATER PUMP

In May, our epidemiological studies revealed a high prevalence of gastrointestinal illnesses, linked to poor water quality. Reports from the teams on the ground also described water pots—commonly used by villagers—that were contaminated with larvae and mud. Some of the poorest residents resorted to drinking unpurified groundwater, exacerbating health risks.

In response, we partnered with Water for Cambodia to install a water pump at the Love Without Boundaries (LWB) Rangsei School. The pump, officially inaugurated on December 13th during a ceremony attended by the village chief now serves the children of the school as well as the residents of Toul Pang Ro Village, a nearby landfill community where many of the students live.

This initiative has had a transformative impact. For the school, it eliminates the $200USD monthly expense on bottled water. For the villagers, it provides access to clean water, addressing a fundamental right and mitigating the root causes of gastrointestinal diseases. The water pump stands as a testament to our commitment to partnering with local assets to innovate sustainable solutions. It also reflects our philosophy of addressing root causes rather than merely treating symptoms.

The success of this project has also deepened our relationships with local stakeholders, including school staff and community leaders. By addressing an urgent need, we have strengthened trust and demonstrated our capacity to deliver tangible, meaningful outcomes.

We extend our heartfelt gratitude to Prof. Arthur Lau of the Yong Loo Lin School of Medicine and Mrs. Eleen Boey for their generous donations, without which this initiative would not have been possible.

(LWB Water Pump Opening Ceremony)

VEASNA & FACE ID

Previously, our screenings relied on physical forms, which required tedious transcription into digital records. To address this inefficiency, we developed an intranet-based clinic management system called Veasna ("fate" in Cambodian). This system allows for seamless data collection and management without the need for internet connectivity, as the villages we work in often have limited internet access. It also enables the automatic generation of referral forms, pre-filling patient fields and data into standardised formats to ensure accuracy and save time.

Additionally, we trialed the use of facial recognition technology so as to be able to retrieve patients' records from previous trips, ensuring continuity of care and enhancing our ability to provide personalised healthcare interventions.

While the system was successfully trialled, it faced significant scaling challenges due to technical difficulties. Despite this, Veasna has proven to be a significant step forward. It has streamlined patient data management, minimised errors, and has the potential to improve the efficiency of our screenings. The lessons learned from this implementation will guide future iterations, ensuring that Veasna becomes a robust and scalable tool for resource-limited settings.

The development of Veasna also provided an opportunity for cross-disciplinary collaboration, bringing together expertise from medical and computing fields. This initiative has reinforced the importance of innovation and adaptability in addressing systemic challenges in healthcare delivery.

We remain committed to refining Veasna to meet the demands of large-scale operations, envisioning its potential to revolutionise clinic management in resource-limited settings. This initiative underscores our belief in the transformative power of technology to address systemic challenges in healthcare delivery.

We extend our heartfelt thanks to Ms. Kimaya Wanjari and Ms. Haridos Sreelakshmi of the School of Computing (National University of Singapore) for their invaluable expertise, without which this initiative would not have been possible.

SCHOOL UPGRADING INITIATIVE

Computer Lab and Sports Programme

Following discussions with the principal of Tum Nub Kor V School, we provided two laptops to address the school's need for administrative efficiency. Previously, worksheets were manually copied onto notebooks, a time-intensive process. The laptops now enable the school to print worksheets and streamline administrative tasks, and encourages the integration of digital learning for the students.

We also identified the need for a more engaging physical education programme. The current curriculum involved only basic stretching exercises. To enrich this aspect of the students' holistic development, we provided equipment for volleyball, badminton and soccer. These additions enabled the students to participate in more dynamic and enjoyable physical activities. This not only promotes physical well-being but also brings a sense of excitement and joy to their school experience.

Both the laptops and sports equipment are under the care of the Tum Nub Kor V School principal. This initiative reflects our broader commitment to strengthening community assets and fostering holistic development. By addressing both administrative and physical activity needs, we aim to provide a more balanced and enriching educational experience.

The feedback from the school's leadership has underscored the importance of such contributions in improving operational efficiency and student engagement. These small yet impactful interventions highlight the value of targeted support in amplifying the capacity of local institutions.

SOAP MAKING

To complement Education's programme at the Love Without Boundaries School, we introduced a creative and educational soap-making activity. This initiative aimed to reinforce hand hygiene practices while sparking joy and creativity among the children. Research has consistently shown that hand hygiene is one of the most effective ways to improve community health, and this activity sought to instil these habits early on.

We facilitated the activity by melting soap blocks and pouring them into artistic moulds. The children were encouraged to personalise their soaps by adding dyes and food colouring. At the end of the activity, they proudly took their creations home for personal use. It was heartening to see many of them immediately using the soaps. Additionally, we gifted extra soap bars to the school to ensure continuity in hand hygiene practices.

Beyond its practical benefits, this initiative provided an avenue for creative expression and engagement. The hands-on nature of the activity fostered a sense of accomplishment among the children, while simultaneously delivering an important public health message. The success of this program has highlighted the potential for interactive, educational initiatives to drive behavioural change in communities.

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Our Development team recognised the importance of enhancing the professional scope of our project by seeking guidance from experienced professionals in related fields. To this end, we invited Professor Alberto Perez Pereiro of NUS College, an expert with over a decade of experience working with vulnerable communities in Cambodia, to deliver a talk to our team. Professor Perez Pereiro shared invaluable insights from his extensive work, highlighting practical strategies for community engagement and sustainable project design.

His lessons emphasized the significance of cultural sensitivity, stakeholder collaboration, and the need to align initiatives with the genuine needs of the communities served. By drawing on examples from his own experiences, he provided actionable advice on refining our methodologies and ensuring that our efforts create lasting, meaningful impact. Additionally, his talk inspired thought-provoking discussions within our team, encouraging us to critically evaluate our current approaches and explore innovative solutions.

The session proved instrumental in helping us to think more critically and holistically about our work. It underscored the importance of continuous learning and professional development, reminding us that the path to meaningful change is iterative and requires a deep understanding of the communities we serve. This concept of tapping into experts and professionals is one we hope to continue in the future. By fostering an interdisciplinary approach and seeking diverse expertise, we aim to ensure our initiatives remain innovative, sustainable, and impactful. We are deeply grateful to Professor Perez Pereiro for taking the time to share his expertise and for his encouragement to remain steadfast in our mission.

FUTURE PLANS

Door-to-Door

Development will continue to refine Door-to-Door surveys to answer pressing, important questions that not only address the pertinent issues faced within the communities we help, but also to connect personally with each villager we interact with.

Our aim for D2D is to continue gathering information that is applied to solutions through initiatives based on real-world experiences, together with the observational insights picked up from being on the ground, all while ensuring that we do not lose the human touch of our work in Poipet. 'Stories of Poipet' was a novel step forward in understanding and reflecting on the lives of villagers, enabling the committee members to connect directly with locals and solidify their purpose in serving the communities.

Veasna

Veasna will be expanded into a substantial sub-committee involving members from Development, Screening and interested individuals to partner with NUS School of Computing students, in an effort to build a holistic team ready to address the current shortfalls and future needs of a longitudinally-sustainable screening process.

Collaboration with Other Partners

Recognising the transformative potential of technology, we have initiated partnerships with professional companies to enhance digitalisation efforts in Cambodian villages. These collaborations focus on refining the Veasna digital health screening system, ensuring it remains accessible and efficient. Additionally, the expertise of these professional partners will support the introduction of digital tools to advance education, healthcare, and community development. By strengthening these collaborations, we aim to create sustainable, tech-driven solutions that address the multifaceted challenges faced by underserved communities.

Stories of Poipet

Building on the success of the Stories of Poipet initiative, we envision showcasing the lived experiences of the Poipet community to a broader audience. This involves collaborating with art galleries, libraries, and cafés in Singapore to host exhibitions featuring the Stories of Poipet pieces. By engaging stakeholders, including the Singapore Medical Association and corporate sponsors, we aim to foster meaningful dialogue about the challenges faced by the community while generating continued support for our efforts. These exhibitions will also serve as fundraising platforms, integrated into events such as Battambar, to further amplify awareness and resources. By sharing these narratives, we hope to inspire deeper connections and sustained advocacy for the Poipet community.

Humanitarian Aid Conference

To foster collaboration and knowledge sharing, we propose organising a Humanitarian Aid Conference in partnership with other Overseas Community Involvement Projects (OCIPs) within our institution. This conference will feature discussions on rural medicine, digital health solutions, sustainable development, and the cultural dimensions of humanitarian work. Distinguished guest speakers will lead these sessions, providing a platform for participants to exchange innovative ideas and best practices. By promoting a culture of continuous learning and improvement, this conference will inspire collective action and ensure our initiatives remain impactful and forward-looking.

These future plans embody our commitment to addressing systemic challenges through sustainable and innovative solutions. By building on our existing efforts and fostering new collaborations, we aim to continue empowering the communities we serve while inspiring meaningful change.

Professional Development

Building on our professional development efforts this year, such as the insightful session with Professor Alberto Perez Pereiro of NUS College, we recognize the immense value of continuous learning and interdisciplinary guidance. To further this, we plan to organise professional development workshops and guest speaker sessions every two months. We hope to explore key topics such as rural medicine, sustainability, business pitching, and other relevant areas to enhance our skill sets as project members. These sessions will provide team members with practical knowledge, inspire innovative thinking, and deepen our understanding of effective humanitarian work, thus fostering meaningful discussions that encourage critical evaluation of our approaches and direction as a project.

By committing to regular professional development activities, we aim to equip our team with the skills and perspectives necessary to drive impactful, sustainable change in the communities we serve.

REFLECTION

Development's role is constantly evolving and fluid. As healthcare challenges grow increasingly complex, ensuring health requires not only a broad, holistic perspective but also a deep understanding of systemic problems and cultural sensitivities. There is limited utility in addressing disease when its root causes lie beyond the confines of the temporary clinics we establish twice a year. To this end, Development's mission is to complement our larger project efforts through partnerships with professional expertise and by tackling issues through a novel, interdisciplinary approach.

Yet, beyond strategic plans and innovative solutions, Development is ultimately about connection. It is about knowing the lives, dreams, and struggles of the people we serve. It is about forming bonds that transcend the immediate and reflect genuine care and commitment. Our work is not just about solving problems; it is about being present—standing alongside the people, listening to their stories, and being the boots on the ground.

While our interventions may seem grand, they are rooted in the simple but profound truth that much of poverty stems from the feeling that no one cares. By being there—physically, emotionally, and wholeheartedly—we aim to affirm that every life matters. It is this deep human connection, this unwavering love for the people, that anchors us and drives our work forward.

Ultimately, Development guides the direction of the entire project. It ensures that our efforts remain focused on the most pressing needs and that our initiatives are grounded in the lived realities of the communities we serve. This role—melding strategic vision with heartfelt compassion—defines the essence of Development and its lasting impact.

PUBLICITY

The Publicity Committee is responsible for the publicity, management of funds, fundraising efforts of Project Battambang as well as volunteer welfare. Much of our work is done behind the scenes to support the other committees and to carry out different roles to assure that our project has the funds and manpower to run smoothly.

Overview:

The Publicity Committee plays a vital role in raising awareness about Project Battambang, both in Cambodia and Singapore. Through consistent updates on our website and Instagram accounts, we ensure that the public stays informed about our efforts and progress.

Beyond outreach, the Publicity Committee works diligently behind the scenes to document and capture meaningful moments throughout our trip. These visuals and stories not only aim to inspire others to support similar causes but also reflect our commitment to transparency and accountability in all that we do.

The team is also responsible for producing the annual Post-Trip Report (PTR), which provides a comprehensive summary of the work accomplished during the trip, including key data, statistics, and reflections. By doing so, we offer a clear and detailed account of the impact made possible by the generous support of our donors and the community.

SOCIAL MEDIA

Through Instagram and video publications, we documented our efforts and celebrated key milestones, ensuring transparency and fostering a connection with our supporters.

Instagram Content:

Throughout the trip, the team maintained an active presence on social media by posting daily updates via Instagram stories to capture every event as it unfolded. These stories provided real-time glimpses into activities such as door-to-door visits, health screenings, and educational initiatives.

Furthermore, we designed curated carousel posts, each consisting of three slides, including a visually engaging reel to bring these moments to life. This helped to build an online archive of our trip while inspiring and informing our supporters.

Water Pump Video Publication:

Following the opening ceremony of the water pump at LWB, our team was in charge of filming and producing a video commemorating this event. This video showcased the transformative impact of the water pump project, which addressed critical water quality issues identified earlier in the year.

FUNDRAISING

To secure the necessary resources, the team reached out to a broad network of potential donors, including past sponsors, alumni, doctors, and companies that had previously supported Project Battambang or other initiatives. Personalized emails were sent to appeal for both monetary support and specific item donations.

This year's outreach efforts were successful, as the team managed to secure sponsorships from several generous donors, whose contributions are highlighted on the following pages. These partnerships were instrumental in ensuring that essential items and funds were available for the project's activities.

WELFARE

Our Cambodian committee plays a vital role in the success of Project Battambang, and we made sure to show our appreciation during this year's Welfare Night. The evening was filled with good food, laughter, and heartfelt moments as we celebrated the bonds we've built throughout the trip.

To thank the Cambodian committee, doctors, and LADS scholars, we gifted them custom wooden coasters and certificates as tokens of our gratitude. It was a night to remember, strengthening friendships and ensuring the connections we've made will last well beyond the trip.

THE BATTAMBANG EXPERIENCE

- 2024 Project Directors -

A STORY WORTH TELLING

As I closed the gates of Mother of Peace Kindergarten (MOPK) for the last time, a bittersweet sigh escaped me. It felt as though those gates symbolized the end of a meaningful chapter in my life. Looking back, parts of me cannot believe it has been two years since I joined Project Battambang.

As with every new member, I was filled with passion, hoping I could make a change in the lives of the local Cambodian Community. Back then, I was tasked with producing a documentary with no specific theme. I then decided that perhaps I should take a glimpse into the lives of the locals. Unknowingly, that was one of the best decisions I have made in this project. Over four days, accompanied by a Cambodian Committee member, my camera in one hand and a tripod in the other, we wandered through the village, interviewing the villagers. Despite the hardships they faced, they shared their struggles and dreams with incredible warmth and generosity. It doesn't matter how many organizations we engage with; the best way to truly understand a place is by learning directly from its people. Some may describe this process as humbling, as though we must lower ourselves to understand their lives, but I question if such a perspective is even necessary. Shouldn't genuine interaction simply involve connecting as fellow human beings, rather than viewing it through the lens of a beneficiary-benefactor relationship? After all, aren't we all fundamentally equals?

Poverty is not merely a condition but rather a perception, shaped by comparing a person's current circumstances to what they could potentially achieve or possess. It highlights the gap between present realities and what could be.

In the grand scheme of things, Poverty is a complex problem that cannot be resolved entirely through small-scale projects like ours due to the finite resources we have and what seems to be an infinite number of villagers, squeezed into squatter houses made of zinc sheets and wooden planks.

Some may then question the purpose of a project like Project Battambang. To me, rather than aiming to “solve” poverty, our goal should be to provide support to villagers as they tide through this tough period. Additionally, the focus should extend to investing in the future—particularly in children and education. Such efforts can help bridge the gap that young people might face as they grow, offering them greater opportunities and the ability to dream big.

While it’s easy to feel that poverty is too vast a problem to tackle, my experiences with Project Battambang have shown me that real change begins with human connection. To future batches of students reading this, I encourage you to remember that Project Battambang is different. It focuses on building genuine relationships with the locals, rather than simply creating the most impressive initiatives. As you journey from Singapore to Poipet, Cambodia, set aside your identity as a medical student or a person from a first-world country. Engage with the locals on a deeper, more personal level, and embrace the beauty of life's simplicity, inspired by their optimistic outlook.

While the gates of this particular chapter of my life have closed, I have no intention of bidding farewell to Project Battambang. I have come to deeply value its purpose and the impact it has on the Cambodian community. In the meantime, I hold onto the hope that the gap between current realities and potential opportunities will continue to narrow. After all, hope seems to be the strongest thing one can hold on to.

Dylan Chew Yi Jie

TILL NEXT TIME

As we departed on our final flight back from Cambodia to Singapore, it was hard to find words to encapsulate the myriad of emotions that I was experiencing. It was slowly sinking in that this was our final departure from the once-foreign lands that have since grown to be a place of familiarity as official committee members of Project Battambang. Over the course of the past year, my batch has grown to be fondly attached to the people of Poipet, from the local partners that make our dreams turn into reality to the villagers that welcome us warmly into their humble abodes. They are the reason for our undying passion, which has pushed us to relentlessly build upon the work of our seniors and to be bold in coming up with new initiatives to better serve them.

When we first joined the project as M1s, I was under the impression that Project Battambang was in a transformative era as it entered post-COVID times. Inevitably, many connections were lost and so did key parts of our history and the work we do. I am proud to say that since then, the project has steadily rebuilt itself and the importance of relationships (both within the committee and with our partners) is highlighted more than ever.

As we retraced the work of previous batches, we also learnt that much of the community in Poipet has changed since then. When we visited villages the project used to serve (like San The Phiep Village and Andoung Thma Meas Village), it became apparent that Cambodia's economic development has started to yield tangible change to these villages. When surveyed, many villagers now have proper houses, access to healthcare and stable employment. Such a finding was heartening, especially since we long realised that a project as 'small' as ours is limited in what we can do and has little influence over larger systemic problems. The best a humble project like us can do is to tide communities through until governmental support effectively reaches them.

This also presented us with an opportunity to redirect our resources towards communities that remain neglected to ensure our work remains relevant. So, we made the daring decision to befriend key stakeholders in Kbal Koh Village and held our first ever health screening there. Kbal Koh Village sits on the border of Thailand and Cambodia and is home to some of the most impoverished families we have met. Many of them collect trash for a living and so they naturally live amidst dust and disease-causing pathogens silently threatening their health. While we may not have changed their lives drastically, we hope to have delivered some comfort through our conversations with them and provide assurance that they too are cared for through our health screenings.

This year, we also placed an increased emphasis on the importance of health education. To complement the temporary relief of health screenings, the team set out to inspire long-term change on a bigger level through establishing systems that work within the restrictions of the local context.

We focused on training and empowering teachers to organise health education lessons and establish routines that promote the health of their students (eg. daily toothbrushing sessions, weekly hair lice washing sessions). The amalgamation of knowledge and resources is what will empower local actors to sustain permanent change in their own communities and institutions when we are away.

During our term, we also saw the birth of many new initiatives. That includes our digital screening application Veasna, building a water pump at Love Without Boundaries, writing our own book Stories of Poipet, holding our inaugural alumni event, equipping village chiefs with blood pressure machines and more. (More information can be found in the following chapters.) The successful implementation of such a wide array of ideas proves our project as a creative platform, whereby each member has the liberty to be innovative and receive support from the remaining team.

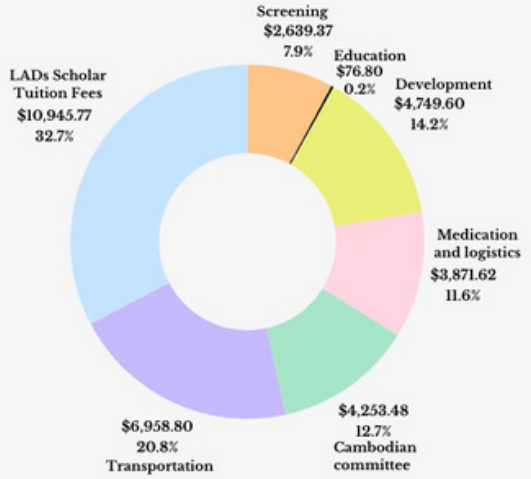
Needless to say, I am filled with great pride when I look back at what we have accomplished. None of it would have been possible without the following people whom I would like to thank. The team, for always showing up and being the most reliable and self-motivated individuals I have worked with. The doctors and alumni, for modelling the way, inspiring us and making time for us despite your busy schedules. The sponsors, for allowing our ideas to come to life. And most importantly, Bong Bondol, the Sisters and all of our local partners for accepting us into their community and for showing us what it means to put the service of others before oneself.

Even as we credit ourselves for all our good work, I am inclined to think that we have received far more from the people of Poipet than we have given or ever will give to the children and villagers we encounter. In their moments of vulnerability, they let us strangers in and trusted us despite having experienced betrayal and estrangement in a society that has seemingly forgotten about them. The lessons they have taught me on love, kindness, generosity, grit and more will live within me for a long time even though our time together was transient. We may not speak the same language or live close to a paralleled life, but I will always think about Cambodia and its people with great fondness and gratitude.

So, even though I am officially 'graduating' from this project, I would like to think that this is not goodbye, it is see you later. It has been a huge honour being a part of Project Battambang and I am fortunate to have found a cause and community so hard to bid farewell to.

Lim Yu En

FINANCIAL REPORT



Total Expenditure = **SGD 33,495.44**

Screening $2,639.37	Purchase of materials required for use during the screening process, and referrals to Poipet Referral Hospital, Mongkol Borey Hospital, and Opticians.
Education $76.80	Purchase of supplies required to conduct LADs camps and Teachers' training.
Development $4,749.60	Installation of a water pump at the Love Without Boundaries (LWB) Rangsei School, as well as the purchase of sports equipment and laptops for the Computer Lab and Sports Programme at Tum Nub Kor V School.
Medication and logistics $3,871.62	Purchase of medications and medical supplies necessary to carry out screenings.
Cambodian committee $4,253.48	Purchase of food, accommodation and welfare for our Cambodian volunteers.
Transportation $6,958.80	Transportation of personnel from the Singapore and Cambodian committee, as well as equipment and logistics.
LADs Scholar Tuition Fees $10,945.77	Scholarships for students from the Light A Dream programme.

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Dr Timothy

Dr Derek Soon

Dr Rayal

Dr Chee Hao

Physiotherapists

Ms Chloe

Ms Sonya

Volunteers

Mr. Min Samoeurn

Ms Ja Suen

Audiologists

Mr Eason

Ms Vivian

Mr Rhithvann Mom

Nurses

Ms Merianne

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Phon Chanseyhakmeaneath
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Hieng Lyhorng
Ly Somnang
Rath Phoumsak
Tang Senghong
Buth Seavmouy
So Sopheap
Than Sonanuth

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LADs Scholars

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Lim Vutha
Khan Sreyneang
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Pich Srey Nich
Bich Sombath
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Leng Sovanareach

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